



Star support: Between 2003 and 2005, Mandira Bedi used her celebrity pull to lift Indian women's cricket, landing sponsors and diverting her endorsement fees to support the squad. THE HINDU PHOTO LIBRARY

comparison, the IPL's eight teams fetched USD 723.59 million in 2008.

Reliance-owned Viacom 18 won the WPL media rights for five years, valued at Rs. 951 crore, translating to a per-match value of Rs. 7.09 crore (USD 866,000). In comparison, the consortium of Sony Television Network and Singapore-based World Sports Group secured IPL's media rights for the first 10 years at a cost of more than USD one billion (USD 908 million going towards telecast rights and 108 million towards tournament promotion). This is roughly Rs. 8,200 crore.

The WPL introduced hordes of new fans to the women's game. Matches were regularly staged in traditional hubs like Delhi, Mumbai and Bengaluru, with Lucknow and Vadodara joining the roster this year. Women's matches, bilateral or otherwise, had long been free-to-watch events played before sparse crowds. Ticketed fixtures in the WPL, priced mostly in the Rs. 150 to Rs. 200 range, changed that.

During the 2013 World Cup, invitations were issued to 50 schools in Mumbai for the opening game at the Brabourne Stadium. Fewer than 2,000 seats were filled. Images of empty stands from that tournament still circulate online. A decade later, both Brabourne and D. Y. Patil Stadium went houseful for several fixtures. Crowds of more than 30,000

attended big matches and weekday games still drew around 10,000 spectators. Its predecessor, the exhibition-style Women's T20 Challenge, was essentially a filler for the IPL. The WPL created a stage of its own, and the women's game took ownership of it.

D. Y. Patil Stadium's emergence as a premier venue was also driven by the WPL. Its batting-friendly pitch and experience at hosting high-profile matches strengthened its case for inclusion, even though it was a privately owned venue, for the home World Cup.

India's commercial allure, long respected and feared in men's cricket, extended naturally to the women's game, drawing top international players eager for contracts worth up to USD 400,000.

Brands embraced the league's visibility. RCB's Ellyse Perry famously broke the window of a Tata Punch EV parked at the sponsor podium. Beyond the instant publicity, Tata pledged a donation of Rs. 5 lakh every time a ball hit the sponsor car during the 2025 season.

Social welfare initiatives also found space. Weeks before the World Cup, the Indian women's team wore a pink jersey through a collaboration with SBI Life to promote breast cancer awareness. UP Warriorz partnered with the United Nations on women empowerment programmes.

"The commercial and cultural changes are there for all to see over three seasons.

We saw a significant rise in interest from brands in new categories, especially women-centric and lifestyle-driven sectors, which saw clear alignment with their audiences. It is no longer viewed as an emerging property. It is now a key platform," Sanjay Adesara, CBO of Adani Sportsline, which owns Gujarat Giants, says.

Across teams, sponsor portfolios have diversified. The Giants have maintained steady backers in Ambuja Cements and Tata Capital while also adding FMCG brands like Himalaya, Patanjali, Hindustan Unilever Ltd., and Amul. Women-centric industries like beauty and jewellery have entered the ecosystem. Mia by Tanishq and make-up brands like Kay by Katrina Kaif have integrated themselves with franchises.

There have been hurdles too, notably the ban on real money gaming. D and P Advisory's valuation report noted that the IPL ecosystem's value fell from Rs. 82,700 crore to Rs. 76,100 crore, while the WPL dipped from Rs. 1,350 crore to Rs. 1,275 crore. Another contributor was the merger of Disney Star and Viacom 18 into JioStar, which consolidated IPL and WPL rights under one roof, removing the two horse bidding battles that previously fuelled rights inflation.

A World Cup win arrived at an ideal moment for a property like the WPL. When the women's IPL was still an idea, many within the system doubted India's depth to sustain a competitive league. Now, the ecosystem is overflowing with talent and there is increasing demand for more teams each season.

"Honestly, the success of the first season is not surprising as a lot of research had gone into it. We had done our groundwork. We spent Rs. 55 crore on brand-building and marketing to showcase a product we believed in and the results are there for everyone to see. If you look at the scale at which BCCI operates, we were very clear that WPL has to be the biggest women's cricket league in